

The man who
shot Ronald
Reagan is seeking
redemption—
this time, in a
Williamsburg
strip mall

Searching for John Hinckley's Record Store

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Photo-illustration by Connie Zheng



Back in December, I Ubered through Colonial Williamsburg—past wood-barrel trashcans and split-rail pens of dirty sheep—to an address that had been tweeted by John Hinckley Jr., the man who shot Ronald Reagan in 1981.

Outside the town center, I cruised a forlorn strip of auto-related establishments, then disembarked at a low-slung building of whitewashed brick. I was looking for Hinckley’s new record store, whose “grand opening,” he’d said online, would occur in one or two weeks.

At first glance, I saw no sign of him. The address was a desolate strip mall: a tax preparer, a Domino’s, a Spanish-language storefront church. As I took it in, a skinny white guy hopped into a pizza-delivery car with a Jesus bumper sticker. A couple of vehicles queued at the Hardee’s by the road. It felt a little surreal. *This* was where I might locate the man who shot the President? Between a vacant party store and a darkened Jazzercise studio? History had spat him out *here*?

I wasn’t frightened, exactly, at the prospect of encountering one of the 20th century’s most troubling lone gunmen. In 2016, after a 30-plus-year, court-mandated psychiatric hospitalization, a federal judge declared that Hinckley was no longer dangerous and approved his release. For a half dozen years, he lived with his mother under various legal restrictions, which were all unconditionally lifted in 2022. At that point, for the first time in 41 years, he was a totally free man. With that liberty, he chose to pursue a creative life.

These days, one typically encounters Hinckley through his YouTube songs; his eBay store, where he sells paintings of his cat; and his social-media posts (“Violence is not the way to go. Give peace a chance,” he notably tweeted after President Trump was shot last July). Hinckley has also been sporadically in the news, mostly for his 2022 attempt at a “Redemption Tour,” in which he booked a series of shows

at music venues across the nation, all of which were scrapped due to public backlash. Hinckley declared himself a “victim of cancel culture,” which got a lot of pickup online.

What made folks queasy about the Redemption Tour seemed to be the attention-seeking, the fact that nobody would have cared about the YouTube croonings of a random 67-year-old in Virginia, but since he’d put a bullet in the lung of an American President, he could trade on notoriety to sell out shows. There was also the eerie resonance with his crime. Hinckley had no political goal when he shot Reagan; he simply wanted to be in the newspaper—to become as famous as Jodie Foster, whom he hoped (due to his acute psychiatric delusions) that his act of violence would impress. In booking the Redemption Tour, Hinckley seemed to want people to look at him, to hear his music, to know his name. The continuity of impulse felt scary, I think. Last time, it didn’t lead anywhere good.

Opening a record shop, though, struck me as a significant humbling. Hinckley would not grow his infamy as a downmarket entrepreneur, the proprietor of a tiny retail store a couple miles from Colonial Williamsburg. If he had his own space, he could—at worst—regale his audiences without fear that his gigs would be shut down. At best, he’d create a little haven where he could sling records and live a life centered on music, which even before the shooting he’d aspired to do.

I guess that’s why I went down there. This version of Hinckley’s redemption seemed more plausible to me—his odd-ball passion project a modest gesture of hope, a stab at a third act from the kind

of person who usually wouldn’t get a second. It also seemed a little doomed. Most small businesses fail.

THE ADDRESS HINCKLEY TWEETED did not include a suite number, so I began searching for him at one end of the strip mall: peering into a darkened boxing gym, the hardwood expanse of the Jazzercise studio, a cramped church with a fake-floral altar. Then I saw a sizable red FOR RENT sign hanging on a grimy storefront window. This must be it, I thought—the future record store. I knocked to no avail.

At the next shop over—an unmarked business with a kitchen of gleaming stainless steel—a man answered the door. I introduced myself as a reporter. “Oh, are you here about Hinckley?” he asked.

This was Chris Waller, a burly food-truck owner in the process of opening a smash-burger spot. “Never met him, never seen him,” Waller said of his rumored new neighbor—but he knew about the record store from an article his dad had shared, which he figured a lot of other people had read, too. “Traffic has increased crazily lately,” he said. “I’ve seen a lot more cars through here in the last few days.”

“How do you feel about him moving in?” I asked.

“Rather not say.”

“Would you buy records from him?”

“No, but I also don’t have a record player. I think most music stores are going out of business with streaming and everything.”

Waller sent me off with a tip: The SPACE AVAILABLE sign had recently come down from the old party store a few doors down, so he figured that’s what Hinckley had leased. But to confirm, he said, I could ask

the landlords; the Extra Space Storage at the building’s very end apparently owned the whole strip.

SEARCHING “JOHN HINCKLEY” ON YouTube returns a mix of results: news segments, documentary clips, and a video of Hinckley’s own—entitled “John

Hinckley Speaks About Peace and Harmony”—which he recorded after Donald Trump was shot. “I know I’m known for an act of violence,” Hinckley says in it, “but I live a peaceful life now.” With a flat and expressionless drawl, he urges listeners to “try and reject violence in all its forms.” The video is stripped down and unpolished; the camera peers up at him, computer screen glinting against his dark aviators. “This is the strangest fucking timeline the world could’ve possibly ever gotten,” the top comment reads.

Mostly, Hinckley’s YouTube is music. There he is—portly and wan, a splash of thinning white hair—singing dozens of mournful songs into his computer while strumming an acoustic guitar. That guitar is the color of caramel and adorned with white block letters that spell out Hinckley’s own name. His songs are classic Americana, coffee-shop fare. They’re earnest. Traditional. His voice is largely in tune.

In Hinckley’s lyrics—which are blunt and rudimentary—one often hears a kind of plea: “I got through the darkest night / Now I hope to make things right.” Or “You never thought I’d be free / You don’t know a different side of me.” Sometimes, when he records a song with his sunglasses off, you can glimpse the man from the mug shot: 25 years old, arched eyebrows, snub nose. In one video, the ghost of that young man sings, “Tomorrow is another day / The best is yet to come / I have found a different way / It’s baffling to some.”

“Redemption” is a key word in the John Hinckley universe—the name of his thwarted tour and his debut album. On his website, he refers to the “National Redemption Party” as the “political wing” of the John Hinckley fan community. Redemption can mean a lot of things: In religion, it’s to be cleansed of sin. In the sense of redeeming a token, it’s to collect something you’re owed. “My definition of redemption is to make amends for all the negativity that I created in 1981,” Hinckley told the *New York Times Magazine* in July. “I’m trying to redeem myself through positive music, through a thing that people really like—as opposed to the things they really hated about me in 1981.”

Hinckley’s life story seems, in some ways, perfectly calibrated to strain the public’s moral intuition about justice. He shot perhaps the highest-profile



1980–81 Unable to make it as a songwriter in Hollywood, Hinckley was obsessed with the film *Taxi Driver* and believed assassinating the President would get the attention of actress Jodie Foster.



1981 After stalking President Carter during the 1980 campaign, Hinckley shot President Reagan and three others outside the Washington Hilton. All survived, though press secretary James Brady was left partially paralyzed, and his eventual death in 2014 was ruled a homicide.



1982 After his arrest, Hinckley twice tried to take his own life in detention. A jury found him not guilty by reason of insanity. Public outcry led Congress and state governments to restrict the insanity defense.



2022 Hospitalized for 34 years, Hinckley was allowed to live with his mother in 2016 under restrictions—the last of them lifted six years later.

target on Earth—plus a cop, a Secret Service officer, and a presidential aide—and was never actually convicted of a crime. The court found him not guilty by reason of insanity, which stirred such outrage among the American people that various laws governing the use of insanity pleas were changed. And, after decades of psychiatric confinement, he walked free. Maybe that’s the law working as intended: rehabilitating a man, then returning him to his life. And maybe it’s a failure of the system. Reagan’s daughter Patti Davis has said as much, writing that she and the other victims’ families still feel the day of the shooting “like a shredded nerve that will never heal.”

Davis opposed Hinckley’s release, but even if you support it, there’s still the question of his music career. What to do with a man who is legally free but behaving—at least to a large swath of the public—in such poor taste? Is it intellectually coherent to believe that Hinckley is entitled to his freedom, but not to use that freedom to seek fame?

In 2022, when Hinckley first announced his Redemption Tour, I reported a short article in which I called around to various DC music venues and asked the owners if they’d hypothetically book him. Bill Spieler of DC9 said absolutely not; he lived in DC in 1981 and remembered the city’s terror. But Sandra Basanti of Pie Shop wouldn’t rule it out. She said she was “very against demonizing people who have a history” and that “if they’ve successfully served their time, they should be allowed to come out and live a life.” Dante Ferrando from the Black Cat told me it would largely depend on Hinckley’s music. While Ferrando had “only listened to, like, a couple seconds of it,” the song he heard “sounded like music. I mean, it sounded like something that would be a legitimate submission.”

All of these answers, disparate as they are, seem like defensible responses to Hinckley’s bid for a public platform. I think that’s part of what’s

CONTINUED ON **PAGE 150**

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JOHN HINCKLEY



CONTINUED FROM PAGE 43

compelling about him, what so rankles the American psyche: He's an unsolvable moral riddle, a persistent and unbanishable ghost. Is his music an attempt to honor the gift of his freedom or a betrayal of it? Does he owe it to the public he terrorized to make himself scarce? Or as someone who's been released, is he entitled to try to make amends?

And is it possible that what he owes society is no longer the question? That maybe, at this point, he deserves to be taken on his own terms, as himself?

EN ROUTE TO THE EXTRA SPACE STORAGE, I indulged in a minor detour, popping into Domino's to ask what its employees might have seen. A graying woman rolling dough knew nothing of any record store, but she seemed less ruffled by the prospect of John Hinckley than by the audacity of his plan. "People still buy records?" she said. "Good for them."

"I really don't care if he has a past," she continued. "If we don't let them work, how are they truly going to be rehabilitated?" But she wasn't confident Hinckley would be able to work at all, since he didn't seem to have much business sense: "There are not any workmen coming and going, and it would seem dumb to open after Christmas, because I would think your sales would not be that great."

"Wait," she said before I left, "so he assassinated JFK?"

Around the corner, I found the airy front office of Extra Space Storage. At the desk, the youngish, hoodied employee initially gave me his full name, then later texted to request I not use it. This was apparently due to his wife's squeamishness that he'd talked to me on the subject of John Hinckley at all—particularly, I assume, because he'd likened Hinckley opening a record store to "the Green River Killer setting up a daycare" and said he would not become a customer.

This man knew nothing of the rental transactions occurring in the storefronts to his left, but he gave me the phone number of someone who would—the facility's commercial-leasing manager, who could tell me if Hinckley was the party store's new tenant. But before I called, I decided to see if Hinckley was there; it seemed possible I might find him inside, industriously setting up shop.

Next to the Domino's, the colorful PARTIES GALORE, CAKES & MORE sign still hung. Through the door, I saw a small front room painted sage, festive stripes of blue and pink ringing the walls at waist height. Behind it were some architecturally odd details: a back room flanked by saloon doors, cabinetry glimpsed through a cutout in the wall. Right out front, maybe 20 feet from the door, flew a faded and tattered American flag.

In his tweet—which is now deleted—Hinckley had claimed that the grand opening was imminent. But this storefront was deserted, lacking any evidence at all of human life: no albums, no decorations, not even a desk or a chair. Standing in the cold, I felt queasy. How had I not taken more seriously that the record store might have been a delusion, that perhaps it was never actually meant to exist?

For years, per the courts, Hinckley was not allowed to speak to the press—in part to curb his grandiosity but also to protect him. An onslaught of attention, it was thought, might derail his delicate transition back to everyday life. That restriction has been lifted, which still doesn't make it defensible for a reporter to hunt him down—to scrutinize the erratic business practices of a mentally ill sexagenarian who spent his adult life sequestered from the world. I knew that when I got on the train to Williamsburg. I went anyway. I told myself it was fine to entertain the possibility that this record store might give him a new life. Undeniably, though, I was also there to wring content from a clinically disturbed man whose future could never outrun his past.

SINCE HINCKLEY WASN'T THERE, I NEEDED to email him for comment, although I had no expectation that he would reply. But that evening, as I rode the Amtrak back to DC, he popped up in my inbox. The record store, he told me, was "on hold." Apparently, he'd gotten some blowback for announcing it and "didn't feel comfortable opening a store when there was such a negative reaction." But the vision, he said, was

to sell his collection of about 1,000 rock albums, plus some guitars. The landlord from Extra Space Storage never returned my calls, but a company spokesperson emailed a statement: "I can confirm John Hinckley expressed an interest in renting the property, but that's where his interaction with us ended. There was no lease agreement finalized."

Contemplating the death—or at least the deferral—of Hinckley's dream, I thought back to a moment at the strip mall, when I waited for an Uber inside a nearby Family Dollar. There, I spoke with a manager, Shemica Parker, a slender woman in gold necklaces and a bright-red MERRY CHRISTMAS shirt. I asked how she felt about John Hinckley moving in a few doors down, and she said, "To be honest, I'm a people's person, I love everybody." But would she buy one of his records? "If his music is good, I would," she replied, then pulled up his YouTube on her phone.

Over a speaker by the register, Hinckley's song "Lonely Dreamer" began to play. We listened for a moment in silence, surrounded by bottles of DayQuil and Roblox gift cards and plastic candy canes filled with Skittles. As Hinckley sang about dreaming his life away and prevailing through troubles, Parker nodded and smiled. "I like this type of music," she said. "A couple of months ago, I was going through something—a terrible, terrible situation. I was alone and daydreaming and sitting there just thinking and thinking and thinking. And once you listen to music like this, it relaxes you."

Parker told me she wouldn't have expected that a man like Hinckley would sing, and we discussed, for a moment, his arc: the shooting, the insanity plea, the hospitalization, his faltering quest for redemption. "People go through things," Parker said. "Some things happen when you go through life. He did the crime, and he did the time, so now just give the man a second chance."

Maybe that day will come—but Hinckley's final emails to me, before he stopped responding, sounded subdued. He said he still hopes, someday, to open his record store in a location that's "safe for [him] and the public." But for now, he wrote, "I'll just keep selling records online." **W**

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